Hasina. Patwardhan's coded message to both the leaders was clear. Ershad was their common enemy and the moment was ripe to renounce their bitter rivalry and join hands. Begum Zia and Sheikh Hasina both agreed that the removal of Ershad was their main objective and other issues could be ignored for a while. This understanding between political leaders who Patwardhan believed were potent forces against the dictator put more pressure on the Ershad regime which had successfully converted an illegitimate rule to legitimate governance.

Meanwhile, on the diplomatic level, every effort was being made to keep the ties between Ershad and the Indian government intact. According to Patwardhan, the Indian establishment aimed to show the world that India was not a troublemaker and its sole intention in Bangladesh was to help set up a people's government.

'I asked the staff to stop the practice of writing memoranda on meetings with sources and paid informers since the typist and the person who filed such memos could leak the information. Any documentation can be compromised. Instead, I encouraged the use of handwritten ciphers depending on the value of the information. Most of our plans were stored in our heads. There was a regime change in India in late 1989 but our operation continued without a glitch. We had recruited most of the leaders of student unions, managed to bring Begum Zia and Sheikh Hasina on the same platform and also ensured that Ershad and his spies knew nothing about our operation,' Patwardhan recalled.

For Pat wardhan, January 1990 could not have had a better start. The R&AW spymaster was able to establish a powerful network of informers within the Bangladeshi government